

## Primary Source Reading 1: The Real Distinction Between Mind and Body

*Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From René Descartes, Meditations on First Philosophy, Meditation VI, translated by John Veitch (1901) Read before Lesson 10b: Substance Dualism*

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**Before you read:** By this point in the *Meditations*, Descartes has already established that he exists as a thinking thing, and has argued that God exists and is not a deceiver. He now uses that foundation to ask a new question: are mind and body genuinely two different things, or just two ways of describing one thing? Watch for the exact move he makes — from what he can *clearly and distinctly conceive* to what must, therefore, really be the case.

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### What Can Be Clearly and Distinctly Conceived

And, firstly, because I know that all which I clearly and distinctly conceive can be produced by God exactly as I conceive it, it is sufficient that I am able clearly and distinctly to conceive one thing apart from another, in order to be certain that the one is different from the other, seeing they may at least be made to exist separately, by the omnipotence of God; and it matters not by what power this separation is made, in order to be compelled to judge them different; and, therefore, merely because I know with certitude that I exist, and because, in the meantime, I do not observe that aught necessarily belongs to my nature or essence beyond my being a thinking thing, I rightly conclude that my essence consists only in my being a thinking thing or a substance whose whole essence or nature is merely thinking.

### Two Distinct Ideas

And although I may, or rather, as I will shortly say, although I certainly do possess a body with which I am very closely conjoined; nevertheless, because, on the one hand, I have a clear and distinct idea of myself, in as far as I am only a thinking and unextended thing, and as, on the other hand, I possess a distinct idea of body, in as far as it is only an extended and unthinking thing, it is certain that I, that is, my mind, by which I am what I am, is entirely and truly distinct from my body, and may exist without it.

### The Faculties That Belong to Mind, and the Faculties That Belong to Body

Moreover, I find in myself diverse faculties of thinking that have each their special mode: for example, I find I possess the faculties of imagining and perceiving, without which I can indeed clearly and distinctly conceive myself as entire, but I cannot reciprocally conceive them without conceiving myself, that is to say, without an intelligent substance in which they reside... I remark likewise certain other faculties, as the power of changing place, of assuming diverse figures, and the like, that cannot

be conceived and cannot therefore exist, any more than the preceding, apart from a substance in which they inhere. It is very evident, however, that these faculties, if they really exist, must belong to some corporeal or extended substance, since in their clear and distinct concept there is contained some sort of extension, but no intellection at all.

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**After you read:** Notice the precision of the argument. Descartes is not simply reporting that mind and body *feel* different. He is claiming that he can conceive of each one, completely, without including anything from the other — and that this kind of clear and distinct conceivability, guaranteed by a non-deceiving God, is enough to prove that they are genuinely separate substances, each capable of existing without the other. Hold onto this conclusion. The next reading will show Descartes almost immediately complicating it.